

CHAPTER SIX

Introduction

The last chapter critically explored certain aspects of the Christological controversies of the 4th and 5th century AD. This chapter returns to one of the objections raised against the Word made flesh doctrine (often dubbed the “heavenly” flesh doctrine).

- If Jesus is the One true God, why did He have to pray, and to whom did He pray?

There are three views that attempt to explain the prayers of Jesus to the Father. The first view is the traditional Trinitarian view which contends that since a person prays, Jesus as the second person of the Trinity prayed to God the Father who is the first person of the Trinity. This view teaches that one person in the Godhead prayed to another. The second view is that of the Oneness theologians who maintain that the human nature of Jesus prayed to the divine nature within Him. In this school of thought, the proponents teach that there is only one person in the Godhead, but when God was manifested in the flesh, the “incarnation” produced a dual nature within Jesus. One nature was fully human and the other fully God. They teach that the

human nature prayed to the divine to solicit help. The third view, which I believe is the correct biblical view, is that of the One God interpretation. This view states that Jesus did not pray to another person outside of Himself or for His own needs or weaknesses. Rather, He prayed *for* fallen humanity. He had come for this very purpose: to be our intercessor. In other words, His prayers were on behalf of helpless, depraved humanity. He was playing the role of High Priest for us and was our advocate.

A brief analysis of the three positions

After having briefly introduced the varying views, let us take a closer look at each one.

One person praying to another view

The first objection raised against this view is that it contradicts all Scriptures in the Bible that declare that God is numerically One. Here are a few examples: Deut 6:4; Deut 32:39; Isaiah 43:10; Isaiah 44:8; Zech 14:8; Mal 2:10; John 1:1,14; Mark 12:29,32; Rom 9:5; I Tim 2:5; I Tim 3:16; James 2:19 & I John 5:20. In the light of these overwhelmingly One God scriptures, it would be inconsistent with the testimony of God Himself to state that One God called Jesus is praying to another God called the Father in a Triune Godhead.

The doctrine of the Trinity, as outlined in the Athanasian Creed, states that the three persons are co-equal, co-eternal and

consubstantial. This begs the question: How can Jesus be said to be co-equal with the Father if He has to pray to Him? Wouldn't His praying imply that He is inferior to God the Father?

It must be pointed out that this view only developed after the doctrine of the Trinity was fully formulated by the church fathers at Nicea (AD 325) and Constantinople (AD 381). The Trinitarian creed raises a welter of questions: Why did Jesus pray to the Father only and not to the Holy Spirit? Why does He say in John 16:26

***John 16:26** At that day ye shall ask in my name: and I say not unto you, that I will pray the Father for you:*

Why does He all of a sudden no longer pray to the Father at that day? A first order of business is to briefly elaborate on the One God position which we believe is commensurate with the Bible.

Establishing the identity of Jesus.

Before I proceed, let me establish a few bedrock biblical facts upon which the subsequent arguments made are premised. God is one (Deuteronomy 6:4) and this implies - not a composite or compound one as the doctrine of the Trinity states - but an indivisible one. The Jews inferred from Deuteronomy 6:4 that God is *he* (Mark 12:32). Even Jesus Himself referred to God as *he* in relation to the creation (Matthew 19:4). So there is One God in a strict monotheistic sense

and not a quasi-monotheistic one as the doctrine of the Trinity (which is essentially a form of crypto-polytheism) declares.

This One God of the Old Testament Himself, and not His pre-existent Son (no such thing as “eternal generation of the Son”), was manifest in the flesh (I Timothy 3:16). God is Word and Spirit (John 1:1, John 4:24); His Word is intrinsic to His being just as your word is an inseparable part of you. His Word was made flesh (John 1:14) and the life of this flesh is the Father Himself (Spirit and Father refer to the same One God). There is sufficient evidence for this:

John 14:10 *Believest thou not that I am in the Father, and the Father in me? the words that I speak unto you I speak not of myself: but the Father that dwelleth in me, he doeth the works.*

John 6:57 *As the living Father hath sent me, and I live by the Father: so he that eateth me, even he shall live by me.*

On the basis of the scriptural evidence thus far we acknowledge Jesus to be none other than the One and only Jehovah of the Old Testament who now indwells a body begotten of His own Word. This rules out any contribution from humanity. When we say Father, Son and Holy Spirit, we are speaking about Jesus because in Him dwells the fullness of the Godhead bodily (Colossians 2:9). With this truth firmly established, let us approach the subject at hand.

Why did Jesus pray?

Jesus prayed for us and His prayers were addressed back to Him since He is the One true God is the short and simple answer. The Word was made flesh not only because blood was necessary for God to atone for our sins, but, in addition, God saw that we were hopelessly weak and there was none to intercede or pray for us. Isaiah repeats this twice.

Isaiah 59:16 *And he saw that there was no man, and wondered that there was no intercessor: therefore his arm brought salvation unto him; and his righteousness, it sustained him.*

Isaiah 63:5 *And I looked, and there was none to help; and I wondered that there was none to uphold: therefore mine own arm brought salvation unto me; and my fury, it upheld me.*

God furnished us with two concrete reasons for His subsequent manifestation in His own flesh and blood. These two elements, which we can isolate from Isaiah 59:16 are the following:

- I. There was *no man*. This means there was no human being qualified to step in and act in the role of redeemer.
- II. God wondered that there was no intercessor.

The Christian world often expends much energy on the first point, and rightly so. For without God manifesting Himself in flesh and blood, there would have been no way to make propitiation (appeasement for the curse of the Law) for our sins. It is the second

point which has not been fully understood in churches and congregations. The fact is that God was manifested in the flesh to also serve as our *intercessor*. Let us never forget that.

Remember the High Priest in the Old Testament? He had a crucial role to play on behalf of the children of Israel. Not only did he take the blood of lambs and bulls into the Holy of Holies, but, just as important, was his role in interceding for the people.

Numbers 16:46 And Moses said unto Aaron, Take a censer, and put fire therein from off the altar, and put on incense, and go quickly unto the congregation, and make an atonement for them: for there is wrath gone out from the LORD; the plague is begun.

Numbers 16:47 And Aaron took as Moses commanded, and ran into the midst of the congregation; and, behold, the plague was begun among the people: and he put on incense, and made an atonement for the people.

Incense represents prayer. It was the prayer of Aaron which saved the children of Israel from certain death. Similarly, Jesus came into this world to pray for us and on our behalf. Note that Aaron was not the one in danger from the wrath of God, yet Moses commanded him to make haste, light the incense and run through the immense crowd perishing in the wilderness for their sins. Jesus, too, was not praying or agonizing for His own sins or His weaknesses as many Christians proclaim, but He was performing the role of our High Priest, our Advocate:

1John 2:1 *My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous:*

Intriguingly, the word translated advocate can also mean “one who pleads another's cause with one, an intercessor” (*paraklētos*). While on earth, and in heaven too, Jesus pleads our cause. What perhaps confuses many who read the Bible is the language Christ adopts while praying for us. For instance,

Mark 14:35 *And he went forward a little, and fell on the ground, and prayed that, if it were possible, the hour might pass from him.*

Mark 14:36 *And he said, Abba, Father, all things are possible unto thee; take away this cup from me: nevertheless not what I will, but what thou wilt.*

Many conclude that the Lord was caught in the throes of an existential struggle. They infer that because He was a human being like you and me, He began to falter under the building pressure. Seven hundred years ago, Isaiah prophesied that many would misinterpret the intercessions of the Lord on our behalf.

Isaiah 53:4 *Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows:*

Isaiah 53:5 *But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed. yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted.*

The above verses are crucial to unlock what was going on in Gethsemane and the other prayers of Jesus. Not only did Jesus intercede for us, He also *bore* our griefs, *carried* our sorrows, was *wounded* for our transgressions, was *bruised and chastised* - all for our redemption and salvation. Now here is the profoundly tragic part of all this sacrifice – the last part of verse 5 says... *yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted*. What a miss of monumental proportions! Isaiah enumerated all that Christ had done for us only to conclude that despite all that, we misunderstood His mission; we deduced that God was afflicting Him for other reasons.

With the above in mind, let us look at the prayers of Jesus in Gethsemane. Understand that the moment the Lord began to feel the pangs of sorrow, the prophecy of Isaiah 53: 4 & 5 became operational. Why would Christ feel sorrow for Himself? Sorrow is integral to sin and the fallen condition. As the sinless Lamb of God, these negative emotions were alien to Christ. What is happening is that *the sins of humanity were imputed to Him*.

Matthew 26:38 *Then saith he unto them, My soul is exceeding sorrowful, even unto death: tarry ye here, and watch with me.*

This was no temporary change of mood that ordinary humans experience resulting from some bad news or bad weather. Rather, as the federal covenantal representative of the human race, Jesus was now formally beginning the process of redemption.

When Jesus said, “Not as I will...”(Matthew 26:39), He was identifying Himself with humanity – He officially verbalized His embodiment as the representative of humanity vicariously. This vicarious representation did not begin at Gethsemane, though. From the moment the Word was made flesh, the process of collective representation was triggered. Even the fact that He was growing up rather quietly and away from the limelight was part of this process of redemption in that He suffered humiliation.

It was the servant-life of the Lord of Hosts, the life of the Sinless One in daily association with sinners, the life of the Holy One in a sin-cursed world. The way of obedience was for Him at the same time a way of suffering. He suffered from the repeated assaults of Satan, from the hatred and unbelief of His own people, and from the persecution of His enemies. Since He trod the wine-press alone, His loneliness must have been oppressive, and His responsibility crushing (Berkhof 2003, 337).

This humiliation is tangible in a paradox: whereas God has always been accustomed to issuing commandments as the Sovereign of the universe and all creation - leave alone submit to anyone - Jesus as a boy growing up in a Jewish milieu had to submit to Mary and Joseph, the elders and Rabbis and every man-made law that regulated His society. This is what the writer of Hebrews was highlighting:

Hebrews 5:8 *Though he were a Son, yet learned he obedience by the things which he suffered;*

Based on the analysis so far, we conclude that the Lord was actually not praying for Himself at all, but for humanity. When He said “Not as I will” or “Not my will”, Christ adopted humanity’s “I” and “My”, fought against it and subdued it through His intercessory prayers for us. Significantly, Irenaeus of Lyon (AD 125-202), explained Christ’s prayers in a very similar manner. His theory is called “recapitulation”.

He has therefore, in His work of recapitulation, summed up all things, both waging war against our enemy, and crushing him who had at the beginning led us away captives in Adam, and trampled upon his head, as thou canst perceive in Genesis that God said to the serpent, “And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed; He shall be on the watch for thy head, and thou on the watch for His heel.” For from that time, He who should be born of a woman, [namely] from the virgin, after the likeness of Adam, was preached as keeping watch for the head of the serpent (Irenaeus, Adversus Haereses, V,XXI, 1).

God was on the “watch” in Christ (II Corinthians 5:17-19) as Irenaeus declares. The Word was made flesh, groaned, agonized and prayed, not for Himself, as some Oneness theologians believe, but exclusively for fallen humanity. We must never take leave of Isaiah’s declaration that all His sufferings, grief, sorrow, chastisement and every other form of buffeting the Lord experienced was not for Himself. The fact that God put on flesh is in itself a “lowering or state of humiliation” which was effected for us alone and not for Himself.

Irenaeus of Lyon stated that every act of Christ can only be understood in light of recapitulating the mistakes of Adam. Adam failed in his duty and responsibility to keep his side of the covenant with God. The consequence of his disobedience had far-reaching effects that encompassed the whole of humanity. This is because Adam was the federal head of the human race. Christ is called the second Adam by the apostle Paul:

1Corinthians 15:45 *And so it is written, The first man Adam was made a living soul; the last Adam was made a quickening spirit.*

If capitulate means to accept defeat, then recapitulate is to be understood as “undoing” the defeat. If the first Adam showed solidarity with us in sin and disobedience, the second Adam showed solidarity with us in obedience and righteousness through His actions.

What does Jesus grew in wisdom mean?

Luke 2:52 *And Jesus increased in wisdom and stature, and in favour with God and man.*

Many are convinced, on the basis of the scripture above, that Jesus’ human nature is alluded to which “increased” in wisdom. According to them, since the divine nature cannot “increase” in wisdom, this must refer to the human nature in Christ. To begin with, this implies

that the so-called “human nature” of Jesus started out with nothing by way of mental content - like the *tabula rasa* (Latin for blank slate or erased slate) of John Locke. This would mean that there were two “entities” in Christ – the perfectly wise God and the perfectly ignorant “human” entity. The ignorant entity, according to this theory, was playing catch up with the perfectly wise one. We are not told to what degree the human entity attained wisdom in comparison to the divine one. Secondly, this theory clearly favours the nurture theory as opposed to nature. In other words, they maintain that Jesus’ knowledge was incrementally gained through the vicissitudes of daily life without deriving any advantage from nature (what we would call genetic inheritance).

Needless to say, this position, despite its popularity, is untenable. The biblical usage of wisdom (Strong’s Gk 4678 *sophia*) is very broad indeed.

1) wisdom, broad and full of intelligence; used of the knowledge of very diverse matters

a) the wisdom which belongs to men

1) spec. the varied knowledge of things human and divine, acquired by acuteness and experience, and summed up in maxims and proverbs

2) the science and learning

3) the act of interpreting dreams and always giving the sagest advice

4) the intelligence evinced in discovering the meaning of some mysterious number or vision

5) skill in the management of affairs

- 6) devout and proper prudence in intercourse with men not disciples of Christ, skill and discretion in imparting Christian truth*
- 7) the knowledge and practice of the requisites for godly and upright living*
- b) supreme intelligence, such as belongs to God*
 - 1) to Christ*
 - 2) the wisdom of God as evinced in forming and executing counsels in the formation and government of the world and the scriptures.¹²*

The list above captures many aspects of wisdom which was common in the Greco-Roman world. In the days of Luke, who was Greco-Syrian, Greeks often distinguished between three or four types of wisdom. In Aristotle's *Nichomachean Ethics*, for example, *sophia* is equated with contemplative and theoretical reasoning about universal truths. *Epistēmē*, from which we get epistemology (a branch of the philosophy of science meaning a theory of knowledge), is often subsumed under *sophia*.

This wisdom is distinguished from another type of wisdom called *phronesis*. *Phronesis* differs from *sophia* in that it emphasizes the ability to not only think rationally about universal truths, but to consciously make choices that promote a good life in practical situations. In other words, while *sophia* is abstract wisdom, *phronesis* is the contextualized practical application of that abstract

¹² Blueletter Bible

<http://www.blueletterbible.org/lang/lexicon/lexicon.cfm?Strongsg=G4678&t=KJV>
Retrieved 11.10.11

wisdom on a daily basis. Aristotle thought *phronesis* was fundamental in political decisions. In the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle lamented the fact that the youth were accomplished in geometry and mathematics but lacked true wisdom which required both *sophia* and *phronesis*. To his mind, *phronesis* required time and maturation. It was intimately connected with experience of diverse life situations.

There is another wisdom called *techne*. This is simply technical know-how or skill. It is concerned with the mechanics of process. For example, a carpenter teaches his son to measure and saw which the son duly imitates and masters.

Keep in mind that all these were aspects of wisdom. Dare we say that Jesus grew in *sophia* understood as a reflection on universal truths? He is the way, the truth and the life Himself (John 14:6) which would make it redundant for him to grow in that kind of wisdom. What about practical everyday wisdom – *phronesis*? Well, if by this Luke means that God negotiated new experiences through His flesh, then a case can be made for that. After all, it was not a common everyday experience for God in flesh to obey His own creation (e.g. Mary and Joseph). In this sense, He did grow in experience. Finally, whether Jesus “learnt” the trade of carpentry in the sense of *techne* becomes an issue open to debate. Did God, the supreme architect, really submit a part of Himself (the mysterious human nature) to a genuine apprenticeship involving a real learning experience? This brief analysis raises a host of questions with

regards to the widespread interpretation of the precise manner in which Jesus “increased in wisdom”. Given such nuances of “wisdom” it is pretentious to claim that Luke was speaking of the human nature of Christ.

Recapitulation and atonement

When Adam blatantly disobeyed God, he undermined and jeopardized the whole foundation of divine order. As the federal head of not only the human family but the whole of the creation order on this earth, which he was to exercise wise dominion over, Adam’s disobedience dismayed God and the holy angels. The nature of our walk with God is something that angels “look into”:

1Corinthians 11:10 For this cause ought the woman to have power on her head because of the angels.

God could not let this breach of divine authority be overlooked. His zeal for His own standards of righteousness had to be upheld. What did He do? The unspeakable wonder is that He robed Himself in flesh and entered the world to succeed where Adam had failed. The paradox is astounding: God who provides for all human needs, allowed Himself to be provided for; God who clothes our nakedness, submitted Himself voluntarily to be clothed; He who knew all things, sat meekly at the feet of finite and fallible minds to “learn from them”; He who holds the fate of nations in His hands,

submitted to the Roman yoke of foreign oppression. The list goes on and on.

Why did He do all this? This was not an exercise in mindless self-flagellation. He did it because of His unfathomable love for you and me. Every other explanation, no matter how theologically erudite or articulate, fails. Indeed, God so loved the world...(John 3:16).

Romans 5:8 But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

Why did Jesus obey and submit Himself to the order of man? Because in so doing He was restoring or recapitulating His own order. Now He was assuming humanity's "I" as His own "I". So the work of atonement (reconciliation between God and man through Christ's shed blood and ministry) did not begin in the Garden of Gethsemane, but much earlier. When Jesus obeyed Mary and Joseph, through Him we obey our parents (a very solemn commandment Exodus 20:12); when He obeyed his teachers and elders, we obeyed through Him; when He submitted to persecution and buffeting, we submitted through Him. Above all, through His obedience and submission, we become righteous.

The last statement is crucial to understanding "Not my will...(Luke 22:42). Ultimately, Jesus did not come to restore a right order between us and our relationship with the world alone, although its importance should not be diminished. He came to restore and heal

our relationship with Him. Before there were parents, children, friends, politicians or such a thing as society in general, there was Adam and God alone. God is zealous for this relationship to be restored. This is why He submitted and *prayed* often – even through the night

Luke 6:12 *And it came to pass in those days, that he went out into a mountain to pray, and continued all night in prayer to God.*

He prayed because we could not pray. Remember that He assumed humanity's "I". In other words, whenever we observe Jesus sighing, praying, crying or agonizing, let us understand that He is performing the role of intercessor on our behalf. He is God; why should He struggle with His own will to obey Himself? God is not conflicted like we humans between the will of the flesh and the will of the Spirit. Oneness theologians are wrong to assert that Jesus prayed because He was a human and human nature is weak. Natures do not pray – persons pray. As Dulles indicated, they are still propounding Nestorianism, a belief in two persons in the one Jesus. This can only be a quasi-monotheism.

Someone may object to the statement, "He prayed because we could not pray". Let me elaborate by soliciting a Scripture verse:

Romans 8:26 *Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.*

Let us scrutinize this verse. Paul is saying that the Spirit helps our weaknesses because we do not know what to pray for. So the Spirit itself prays for us. Now, here is the \$ 64,000 question: Who is the Spirit praying to? The answer should be equally straightforward – to God Himself (who is the same Spirit). However, we don't formulate it in this manner because of the awkwardness of the statement. But technically this is really what is happening. If one can comprehend this, it should not be a problem at all to accept that Jesus' prayers in the Garden of Gethsemane (and throughout His life) were not for Himself but for humanity. With moanings and groanings He made intercession for us.

Irenaeus of Lyon subsumed all the sufferings of Christ under the framework of recapitulating Adam's sin. Several of these can be demonstrated:

- i. God cursed the earth with thorns and thistles. Jesus willingly appropriated this curse upon Himself literally in the form of a crown of thorns (Genesis 3:18; John 19:2).
- ii. The sweat on Adam's face was to remind him of the curse. During the passion week, when the work of atonement was about to reach a climax, Jesus' brow filled with great drops of sweat (Genesis 3:19; Luke 22:44).
- iii. We can only imagine the utter despair Adam felt when he was expelled from the presence of God. Jesus re-enacted this utter despair with the heart-rending cry "...My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? (Genesis 3:23,24; Mark 15:34).

- iv. There is a place of eternal darkness reserved for sinners. Our precious Lord experienced darkness on the Cross to spare us being cast into outer darkness (Matthew 25:30).
- v. Hell is a place of excruciating and unquenchable thirst. He who is the eternal well of life, thirsted on the Cross so we do not have to experience the thirst of the rich man in hell (John 19:28).

These are some of the examples that underscore Christ's vicarious role as our intercessor. Following Isaiah 59:16 & 63:5, God saw no man and no *intercessor*. This is why He alone as the sinless Lamb of God had to perform this role. It is not a case of the second member of the Trinity praying to the first member of the Trinity which diminishes the glory of God who declares, "...and I will not give my glory unto another (Isaiah 48:11), neither is it the equally fallacious contention that one nature prayed to another, but God praying for us through the medium of His own flesh.

Isaiah 53:12 ...and he was numbered with the transgressors; and he bare the sin of many, and made intercession for the transgressors.

Isaiah 63:3 I have trodden the winepress alone; and of the people there was none with me...

We need to thank the Lord for this extraordinary love and sacrifice. Isaiah begins the powerful chapter of the "Suffering Servant" with the words, "Who has believed our report? and to whom is the arm of the Lord revealed?" (Isaiah 53:1). There is a tone of sad indignation secreted into one of the most majestic prophetic revelations of the

Old Testament because many have not believed this report, or misinterpreted Christ's intercessions and sufferings. The truth is all Jesus did was not for Himself, but for you and me. We are all like Peter, desperately in need of Jesus' prayers.

***Luke 22:32 But I have prayed for thee, that thy faith fail not:
and when thou art converted, strengthen thy brethren***

I will conclude this chapter with the beautiful and apt words of the hymn "Who am I?"¹³

*When I think of how He came so far from glory
Came to dwell among the lowly such as I
To suffer shame and such disgrace
On Mount Calvary take my place
Then I ask myself this question
Who am I?*

*Who am I that the King would bleed and die for
Who am I that He would pray not my will, Thy Lord
The answer I may never know
Why He ever loved me so
But to that old rugged cross He'd go
For who am I?*

*When I'm reminded of His words
I'll leave Him never
If you'll be true I'll give to you life forever
Oh I wonder what I could have done
To deserve God's only Son
To fight my battles until they're won*

¹³ To the best of my knowledge, the copyright has expired and the hymn is now in the Public domain.

For who am I?

*Who am I that The King would bleed and die for
Who am I that He would pray not my will, Thy Lord
The answer I may never know
Why He ever loved me so
But to that old rugged cross He'd go
For who am I?
But to an old rugged cross He'd go for, who am I?*

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Sinless Heavenly Man

This chapter will concern itself with another Christological offshoot which has struggled to garner unanimous consensus among denominational theologians, especially in the last couple of centuries (Crisp 2007). I have briefly explored this subject in chapter 1:2, but this chapter takes a different approach and focus. To be blunt, this is an issue which those who hold to a human body and nature for Christ wrestle with. Having concluded that the flesh of the Lord is of earthly origin, it follows logically that they further must accept some form of fallibility for this flesh. For those of a One-God persuasion, who do not adhere to a human flesh for Christ (i.e. of the dust), the debate is *non sequitur*. To explore and fill the lacuna between these two positions, we will need a statement of the problem under investigation:

- Hypothetically, could Jesus have sinned? And if the answer is no, would it not imply that His humanity was a charade? This must be addressed in conjunction with Hebrews 2:17 & Hebrews 4:15.

To help us unpack the above we will need to canvass two contending positions which stem from Chalcedon. What this means is that they